

TIOBE Index March 2026

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

The TIOBE Programming Community Index measures programming language popularity based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites. Updated monthly since 2001, it reflects how much a language is discussed and sought after on the public internet.

50+

Languages Tracked

20+

Search Engines

25

Years of Data

300+

Monthly Updates

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026 TIOBE Index

Rank	2025	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Obj Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

21.25%

Python leads, but lost 2.59 points YoY — the largest drop among the top 5.

+2.02%

C surged from 4th to 2nd, posting the biggest gain among top languages.

48.97%

Top 4 languages hold nearly half the total index — extreme concentration.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 – The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

GAINERS

Perl **+13 spots** **+1.05%**

24th → 11th | Surprising revival in infrastructure and text processing

R **+7 spots** **+0.94%**

16th → 9th | Strong growth in statistical computing and data science

Swift **+6 spots** **+0.44%**

26th → 20th | Re-enters top 20 driven by Apple platform growth

Assembly **Holds** **+0.42%**

17th → 17th | Embedded systems and low-level demand remains steady

LOSERS

Go **-9 spots** **-1.49%**

7th → 16th | Sharpest drop of any top-20 language; possible Rust displacement

C++ **-1 spot** **-2.90%**

2nd → 3rd | Largest absolute rating loss despite holding 3rd place

Java **-1 spot** **-2.37%**

3rd → 4th | Continued long-term decline from its mid-2000s dominance

PHP **-5 spots** **-0.25%**

13th → 18th | Gradual decline as web frameworks diversify

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python's Rise

From unranked pre-1991 to #1 — 25 years to reach the top. Peaked above 25% before settling at 21.25%.

C's Resilience

The only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.

Java's Decline

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+, now fallen below 8%. A cautionary tale of platform shifts.



Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE Programming Language of the Year Award — Given to the language with the largest annual rating gain

2025

C#

2024

Python



2023

C#

2022

C++

2021

Python



2020

Python



2019

C

2018

Python



2016

Go



6

Python Wins

2007, 2010, 2018,
2020, 2021, 2024

C# won in 2023 and 2025, reflecting continued .NET ecosystem growth.

Go's 2016 win preceded its current decline to 16th.

Note: 2017 winner not available in source data. Go's 2016 win preceded its current decline to 16th.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Key findings and strategic implications for technology decision-makers

Python: Dominant but Declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin — yet its -2.59pp YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Monitor whether this signals a plateau or the start of a longer trend before committing to Python-only hiring strategies.

C's Resurgence Matters

C surged from 4th to 2nd (+2.02pp), driven by embedded, IoT, and systems programming demand. Teams building performance-critical infrastructure should account for growing C talent availability.

Legacy Language Revival

Perl (+13 spots), R (+7 spots), and Fortran (top 15) are thriving in infrastructure, data science, and scientific computing. Don't dismiss "legacy" languages when building teams for these domains.

Go's Sharp Fall, Rust's Steady Rise

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49pp) — the steepest fall of any top-20 language. Meanwhile Rust holds steady at 14th (+0.09%). For new systems work, evaluate both before defaulting to Go.